

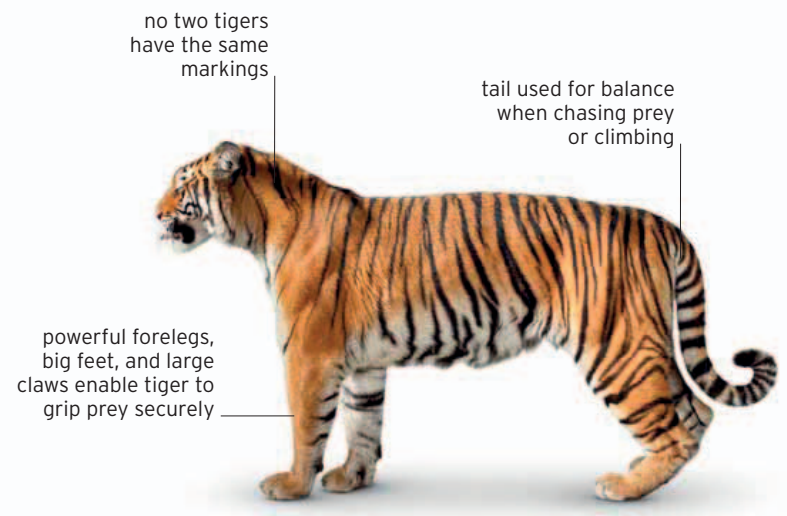
Bengal tiger

Panthera tigris tigris

The tiger is the largest of all the big cats. Five subspecies remain alive today, of which the Bengal tiger is the most common. It is found in a wide range of forest and mangrove habitats in India and Bangladesh. The Bengal tiger's distinctive coat is a deep orange with white undersides, chest, throat and parts of its face, and dark stripes. The Amur tiger (*P. t. altaica*), which lives to the north in the coniferous forests of Siberia, Russia, is the largest of the five. It is the lightest in color and has the longest, thickest coat to cope with the freezing winters. The southernmost subspecies, the Sumatran tiger (*P. t. sumatrae*), is also the smallest, being a good 30 percent smaller and weighing about 50 percent less than its massive cousins to the north.

Ambush attacker

Tigers are chiefly nocturnal but will hunt by day in places where they are undisturbed by daytime human activities. The tiger uses its sense of smell and hearing to detect and track prey. Its great strength and speed mean it can bring down prey that is at least as large as it is, sometimes more so. The Bengal tiger typically hunts hoofed animals, such as gaur, sambar, chital, and wild boar, and stalks them while hidden by the undergrowth. Once the tiger is close enough, it will



launch a lightning strike, surging out of cover and using its weight to knock the prey to the ground. The tiger then delivers a deadly bite to the throat, which crushes the windpipe, leading to death by strangulation, or breaks the neck. Small prey are often killed with a bite to the neck. The tiger then hauls the carcass back into the undergrowth to eat. Despite the tiger's great killing potential, only one in 20 ambushes is a success.

Solitary cat

An adult tiger lives alone. It marks out a territory by scratching marks on tree trunks and rocks with its claws and leaving piles of feces in prominent places. The tiger also scent marks by spraying squirts of urine mixed with oils from a scent gland under the tail, and it gives out roars that can be heard 1 mile (2km) away.

A tigress breeds every two or three years, and changes in her scent will attract a nearby male. The pair roar to each other as they get near and will live together for a few days, mating around 20 times before going their separate ways. Tigresses give birth to litters of up to six cubs, but half of them will not reach two years. Surviving cubs stay with their mother for up to two years, learning to hunt alongside her from the age of six months. They may breed when four or five years old.



△ SUMATRAN TIGRESS AND CUB

The smaller size of the Sumatran tiger (*P. t. sumatrae*) is an adaptation to life in the dense undergrowth of the swamp forests of Sumatra.

Tiger cubs often have practice fights, gaining the speed and agility they will need as territorial adults